Abdulgani L. Yusop

Al-Ustadz AbdulGhani L. Yusop Al-Haj Al-Azhari (rahimahullah), widely known as **Grand Mufti Abdulgani L. Yusop**, was one of the most distinguished Islamic scholars and religious leaders in the history of the Philippines. Born on Sacol Island, Zamboanga City, he rose from humble beginnings to become the highest Islamic religious authority across the Zamboanga Peninsula, Palawan, and much of the Bangsamoro homeland in Southern Philippines. A graduate of Al-Azhar University in Cairo, he was elected by a Mindanao-wide assembly of Ulama in 1989 as the first Grand Mufti of the Darul Ifta' Region IX and Palawan, an institution he founded and led until 1997. He is remembered as a man of profound learning, rare humility, and extraordinary courage: a scholar who stepped into conflict zones not with weapons but with wisdom, and who made the Islamic tradition a force for healing rather than division.

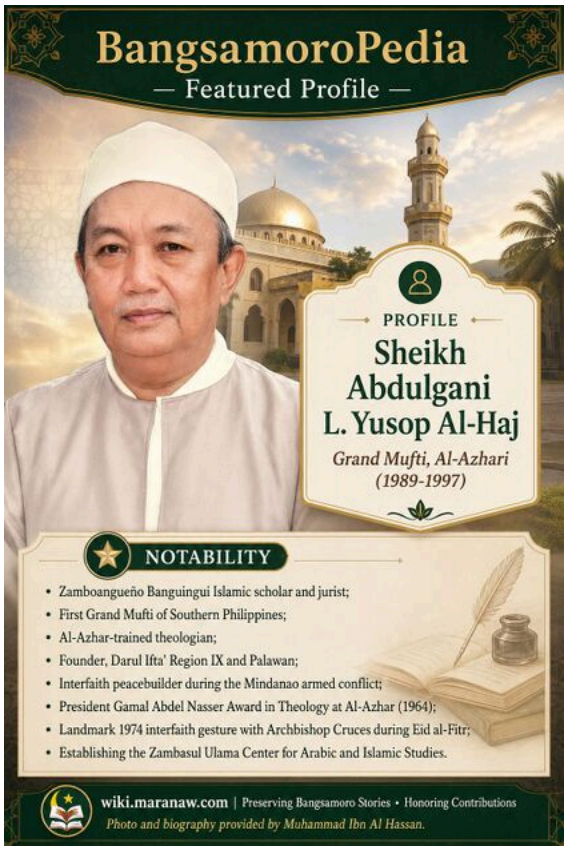
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BACKGROUND

Abdulgani L. Yusop was born on Sacol Island, Zamboanga City, into a family that carried both noble lineage and deep religious purpose. On his father's side, his family held a position of strong religious leadership within the Banuwa Bangingih Tribal Hierarchy. His maternal lineage traced back to Indonesia, to the generation thirty years after the death of the Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him), connecting him directly to the earliest missionaries who brought Islam to the Philippine archipelago. His household was modest in material terms but rich in faith, learning, and a sense of sacred responsibility. That dual inheritance, of tribal leadership and missionary piety, would shape the entire arc of his life's work.

Grand Mufti Abdulgani L. Yusop Al-Haj



Full Name

Al-Ustadz AbdulGhani L. Yusop Al-Haj Al-Azhari

EDUCATION

His religious formation began at a remarkably young age. At nine years old, his uncle Sheikh Jamil brought him as a pilgrim to the Holy Land, where he was placed in the care of an Arab family and enrolled in the prestigious Al-Falah Islamic School in Mecca. This was no ordinary enrollment: the school was, at the time, open exclusively to Arab students, making young Abdulgani the sole non-Arab student in the institution. His immersion in the Arabic language and Islamic tradition was so complete that he would later quip with characteristic wit: "My father is an Arab from the Philippines." He spent his formative years in Mecca during an era before the oil era had transformed the city. The holy shrines were lit by kerosene lamps, and the atmosphere was one of deep austerity and devotion, a fitting crucible for the scholar he was becoming.

At nineteen, he journeyed to Cairo and enrolled at Al-Azhar University, then already more than a thousand years old and the foremost center of Sunni Islamic learning in the world. He completed a degree in Islamic Studies and a Master's degree in Islamic Philosophy, with specializations in Fiqh (Islamic Jurisprudence) and Usulud-Din (the Roots of Religion, covering Islamic Theology and Creed). His academic distinction was remarkable: at his graduation in 1964, he was singled out as the only Asian student to receive the President Gamal Abdel Nasser Award in Theology, placing him among the finest scholars produced by Al-Azhar in his generation.

Before returning home, he traveled extensively to Islamic educational centers across the world, studying how each institution functioned and gathering insights that would later shape his vision for Islamic education in the Philippines.

CAREER

Upon completing his studies, Abdulgani Yusop was offered the opportunity to serve as a missionary to any Arabic-speaking country in Africa, a position of considerable honor from Al-Azhar. He declined. His heart was set on Mindanao, and he returned home with a firm conviction that the Muslim people of the Philippines were on the threshold of an Islamic revival.

His first major contribution upon return was in education. Drawing on his observations of Islamic institutions around the world, he established several Islamic madrasahs across the region. Chief among them was the Zambasul Ulama Center for Arabic and Islamic Studies, which became a foundational institution for Islamic learning in Western Mindanao.

Also Known As

AbdulGhani Yusuf Al-Azhari (rahimahullah)

Born

Sacol Island, Zamboanga City, Philippines

Creed and School

Sunni Ash'ari ('Aqeedah); Shafi'i (Madh'hab); Scholar of Tasawwuf and Ilmul Kamaasan

Office

Founder and First Grand Mufti, Darul Ifta' Region IX and Palawan (1989–1997)

Education

Al-Falah Islamic School, Mecca; Al-Azhar University, Cairo (B.S. Islamic Studies; M.A. Islamic Philosophy)

Award

Golden Amazing Leaders in Islam (ALI) Awardee, 2016 — Golden Crescent Consortium of Peace Builders and Affiliates Inc.

Notability

Zamboangueño Banguingui Islamic scholar and jurist; First Grand Mufti of Southern Philippines; Al-Azhar-trained theologian;

In 1989, he was unanimously elected by a Mindanao-wide conference of Ulama as Grand Mufti for Southern Philippines, the highest religious office for Muslims in the region. As founder and first Grand Mufti of the Darul Ifta' Region IX and Palawan, he institutionalized a framework of religious authority grounded in the Ahlussunnah wal Jama'ah tradition: Ash'ari in creed, Shafi'i in jurisprudence, and balanced in its embrace of the spiritual sciences of Tasawwuf.

Throughout his tenure and beyond, he served as a trusted arbiter in religious disputes, a counselor to government leaders, and a guide to the Mujahideen. He was known for welcoming all who came to his door, receiving them with a cup of tea and the unhurried wisdom of a man fully at peace with his knowledge. Those who knew him said simply: he was a man for all seasons.

Founder, Darul Ifta' Region IX and Palawan; Interfaith peacebuilder during the Mindanao armed conflict

Known For

Founding the Darul Ifta' Region IX and Palawan (1989); landmark 1974 interfaith gesture with Archbishop Cruces during Eid al-Fitr; President Gamal Abdel Nasser Award in Theology at Al-Azhar (1964); establishing the Zambasul Ulama Center for Arabic and Islamic Studies

INSTITUTIONAL CONTRIBUTIONS

Darul Ifta' Region IX and Palawan

The Darul Ifta' Region IX and Palawan, which Grand Mufti Abdulgani Yusop founded in 1989, remains the most significant institutional legacy of his leadership. As the Supreme Council for Islamic Preaching and Guidance for the Zamboanga Peninsula and Palawan, it has served as the religious backbone of Muslim communities in the region for more than three decades after his tenure. The creed, jurisprudence, and spiritual orientation he embedded in the institution, Ash'ari, Shafi'i, and Sufi, remain its defining character to this day.

Zambasul Ulama Center for Arabic and Islamic Studies

Among the madrasahs he established, the Zambasul Ulama Center for Arabic and Islamic Studies stands out as a cornerstone of Islamic learning in Western Mindanao. The Center trained generations of scholars and teachers, and its graduates have gone on to serve Muslim communities across the region.

Mentorship and Scholarly Formation

His students include Senior Sunni Sufi Scholar Sayyiduna Shaykh Khadraji Guru Bata Tapsi Al Ash'ari Ash Shafi'i (Ameer of Sabielal Muhatadin) and former NCMF Commissioner and Sunni Sufi Scholar Prof. Yusuf Morales, figures who themselves became pillars of Islamic scholarship in the region.

PEACE ADVOCACY AND INTERFAITH DIALOGUE

Grand Mufti Abdulgani Yusop is perhaps best remembered for his extraordinary acts of peacemaking during one of the darkest chapters of Mindanao's history. In 1974, at the height of the armed conflict in Mindanao, he invited Archbishop Cruces to join him inside the masjid during the Eid al-Fitr prayers, following the month of Ramadan fasting, at Campo Muslim, Zamboanga City. In that single gesture, a Muslim Grand Mufti welcoming a Catholic Archbishop into the house of Islamic worship at its holiest moment, he sent an unmistakable message to both communities: the war was not between Muslims and Christians, and it was not a religious war. It was driven by political causes, and the path forward lay in mutual understanding, not mutual fear.

He was a central figure in many peace mediation panels, a constant partner in efforts to bring lasting peace to Mindanao. He taught that the resolution of conflict required a genuine recognition of the culture of unity in diversity, and that peaceful coexistence was not merely a political arrangement but a spiritual obligation rooted in Islamic teaching.

SCHOLARLY TEACHINGS

His teachings on prayer, Quranic recitation, trust in God, and the ethics of conduct have been preserved and passed down through his students and community.

Among his most celebrated instructions was his guidance on approaching the Quran with progressive depths of consciousness:

> "Make it a habit to read daily the Holy Quran, and consciously when you read — as if you were hearing the Holy Prophet narrate those verses to his followers; then as if you were hearing the Archangel Gabriel narrate those verses to the Holy Prophet; then as if you were hearing Allah narrate those verses to Archangel Gabriel; then as if you were hearing Allah narrate those verses directly to you; then finally, as if you were hearing the voice and the verses are One... It will penetrate into your core and you internalize its teachings and grasp some of its hidden treasures."

On the purpose of prayer, he taught:

> "The end result of Salah is enjoining good and forbidding evil. When we still do evil, not doing good deeds to ourselves, to our families, to our fellow humans and other creation — then know that our Salah have not been accepted yet."

On the ethics of integrity and trust in God:

> "Be the tricked (betrayed/fooled) rather than the treacherous. Leave all your affairs to Allah, and do not seek revenge."

On the nature of knowledge:

> "There are many knowledgeable now, yet only a few are keen in understanding."

LEGACY

The legacy of Grand Mufti Abdulgani L. Yusop Al-Haj is not preserved in monuments but in people: in the scholars he trained, the communities he guided, the institution he founded, and the vision of Islamic leadership he embodied. He demonstrated that a Muslim scholar can be simultaneously a man of the highest learning and the deepest humility, a guardian of classical tradition and an active agent of modern peacebuilding.

He is remembered not merely for what he achieved but for how he lived: welcoming everyone at his doorstep, joking gently with the young, never turning away the elders who sought to learn, receiving the mighty and the struggling with equal grace. He was, in the words of those who loved him, a man for all seasons, his character seasoned by a knowledge of Islam that was not merely intellectual but transformative.

His life demonstrated in practice what he preached in teaching: that scholarship serves humanity, that peace is a religious duty, and that the greatest leaders are those who make themselves servants of all.

May Allah be pleased with his soul, and may his legacy continue to illuminate the path of those who follow.

RECOGNITION

- Golden Amazing Leaders in Islam (ALI) Awardee, 2016 — Golden Crescent Consortium of Peace Builders and Affiliates Inc. in partnership with Action Bridges Aspirations (ABA) Trainings (posthumous)
- President Gamal Abdel Nasser Award in Theology, Al-Azhar University, Cairo, 1964 (only Asian recipient in his graduating class)

SEE ALSO

- Darul Ifta' Region IX and Palawan
- Zambasul Ulama Center for Arabic and Islamic Studies
- Islam in the Philippines
- Bangsamoro Islamic jurisprudence
- Interfaith dialogue in Mindanao
- Al-Azhar University

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Photo and biography provided by **Muhammad Ibn Al Hassan** (https://www.facebook.com/muhammad.ibn.al.hassan.2025)

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